

ARCHITECTURE / ROBERT CAMPBELL

An entertaining, belated requiem for modernism

"All emotions . . . were abhorrent to his cold, precise but admirably balanced mind. He was, I take it, the most perfect reasoning and observing machine that the world has seen."

Who was this machine for observing? Mies van der Rohe? The younger Le Corbusier?

The words were said by Dr. Watson about Sherlock Holmes, but they could just as well be describing the "scientific" pose struck by many 20th Century architects, few of whom ever saw the inside of a lab. Holmes embodied a kind of popular-magazine idolization of science that was a worldwide fashion in the years when the pioneers of modernism were growing up.

It was all talk. Far from being scientists, Sherlock Holmes, and Mies and Corbusier too, were incurable, intuitive Romantics. Poetry, not science, was what they were about.

That the poetry was elitist and Mandarin and contemptuous of public acceptance is the claim of a new book, "The Failure of Modern Architecture," by a young New York architect, Brent

Brolin. The Sherlock Holmes analogy is only one of the entertaining comparisons that make Brolin's book something few volumes on architecture ever are — intelligent for architects, yet free enough from priestly jargon to be worth the interest of a general readership.

Brolin's title recalls Peter Blake's article "The Folly of Modern Architecture," which appeared two years ago in the Atlantic, and so do his conclusions. In fact, it sometimes seems that the whole architectural world has suddenly started muckraking modernism.

Since the great modern masters probably were, as a group, the most self-righteous dogmatists since Calvin, it isn't surprising that the reaction, now that it's come, is as gleeful as it is intense. Brolin's book is among the first to try to codify this very general reaction, to try to put together a consistent, orderly attack on the historical foundations of the modern movement. The book is a kind of post-crisis evaluation done for himself, his peers and the public.



"Modern, Western-style housing is inefficient and ugly in contexts like this in Afghanistan," Brolin writes in "The Failure of Modern Architecture."

Brolin argues that modernism was a self-validating cluster of concepts that grew out of long-dead battles of the 19th Century and lived on into our own day. It had little to do with the way architecture really is practiced and even less to do with what non-architects might like or dislike.

Throwing out traditional styles, including all decoration and historical allusion, modernists substituted a new palette of "functional" forms which they claimed were based on "truth" and "reason." In this way modernism one-upped its critics by claiming a corner on morality.

In fact, though, the so-called functionalism was just another style, and simplicity and lack of ornament, along with various other fads, were admired

whether they served any purpose or not.

Unexpectedly, the rest of the world stubbornly failed to be converted to the new ideology. Modernism degenerated into a mere game, in which you showed you were a member of the in-group by shocking the bourgeoisie. Thus, Brolin notes that traditional methods of regulating sunlight — awnings, trellises, grilles, shades, shutters and porches — are just as effective as tinted glass or Corbusier's concrete sunshades. The choice is one of style, therefore of self-identification, and modernism usually made whichever choice flew most of in the fact of middle-class expectations.

Modernism also believed in a world-wide industrial culture that

would sweep aside what were called the "cobwebs" of tradition and localism. "I propose one single building for all nations and climates," trumpeted Le Corbusier as late as 1937, sounding, as Brolin writes, exactly like a European missionary out to convert the heathen.

The result was the inane proliferation of modern-style buildings all over the world, often in places where they were disastrously inappropriate. Brolin cites Le Corbusier's own city of Chandigarh in the Punjab as an example, pointing out all the unconscious Western assumptions that governed the design of this new town, and how many of them failed to be useful or even comprehensible to the inhabitants.

Brolin's book is in one way disap-

pointing. It's a little late. As always happens, architects were the last to see that their system of belief, once so fresh and rebellious, had hardened into a Mandarin dogma. It was the public which first pointed out "the failure of modern architecture."

So this book, like others of its type, is a little narcissistic, obsessively rehashing the private past instead of pointing the way to new methods. Modernism as Mandarinism is surely already dead and doesn't need so much killing.

It's time to emphasize that there also were a lot of terrific and necessary ideas in the modern movement and to start sorting them out.